



DIDO AND AENEAS, SET DESIGN

Illustration of the set for Purcell's opera *Dido and Aeneas*, designed by Francesco da Bibiena in 1712. Bibiena, an architect, not only built theaters, but was famous for his spectacular set designs.

Building a career

For the next decade, Purcell's career centered on court and chapel, with the production of verse anthems, royal odes, royal welcome songs (in which the music repeatedly transcends the sycophantic texts), and, in 1685, coronation anthems for James II. His sets of viol fantasias and the Italianate sonatas in three and four parts reveal his genius, not least in their rich chromatic harmonies. The poignantly concise *Dido and Aeneas* (c. 1683–1689) tells the story of the love between Aeneas, hero of Virgil's epic poem the *Aeneid*, and the Carthaginian queen Dido, who